

Academic Writing (BETA)

Seminar I



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Today's programme

- ▶ Course overview: topics, goals, programme, assignments
- ▶ An introduction to features of Academic English
- ▶ Writing exercise



Course Aims

- ▶ introduce students to the basic requirements of formal writing in English
- ▶ develop students' academic writing skills with regard to a) accuracy and b) clarity of expression.
- ▶ introduce students to the basic conventions of using sources through quoting and paraphrasing



Course Content

- ▶ The course consists of six one-hour lectures and six two-hour seminars on theory and practice of academic writing in English. The subjects covered are the following:
 - ▶ Academic style: formality, use of academic phrases
 - ▶ Quoting, referring and avoiding plagiarism
 - ▶ Structure: Introduction, thesis statement, paragraph structure
 - ▶ Linguistic accuracy: grammar, vocabulary and punctuation
 - ▶ Clarity of formulation: linking language, clause combining



Weekly schedule

Week	Lecture	Seminar	Assignment deadlines
1	'Why Academic English?': Introduction to Academic Writing	Dos and don't's in academic writing Introductory writing exercise	
2	'I want to tell you something': The structure of introductions	Structure: Introductions Language: Grammar issues	Friday 11 April: Assignment 1
3	'Standing on the shoulders of giants': Quoting and referring	Structure: Use of sources Language: Summarizing and paraphrasing	
4	'Writing with hamburgers': Paragraph structure	Structure: Paragraphs Language: Linking language and clause combining	Friday 25 April: Assignment 2
5	NO CLASS	NO CLASS	
6	'The take-home message': How to write a conclusion	Structure: Conclusions Language: Punctuation	Friday 9 May: Assignment 3
7	'Dressing for the occasion': Academic Style	Structure: Text Plans Language: Formality	
8	NO CLASS	NO CLASS	Friday 23 May: Assignment 4
9	NO CLASS	NO CLASS	

Assessment & requirements

- ▶ Obligatory attendance (short version: missing 1 session is ok, missing 2 sessions means extra assignment)
- ▶ Active participation in the seminar
- ▶ Four required assignments



Assignment 1

- ▶ Write a 3-sentence 'elevator pitch' to introduce what you want to write your final essay on.
- ▶ Articles can be found in the database on Canvas, but you can also choose your own articles, as long as they are academic.
- ▶ Choose according to your interest, because this is the topic you will be working with for the rest of the course.
- ▶ The text will be graded (pass/fail) on the following aspects:
 - ▶ Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
 - ▶ Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
 - ▶ Use of sources: indication and incorporation of sources in the text; use of referencing style; no traces of plagiarism
- ▶ If you get a fail, you will need to hand in a new version within a couple of days.



Assignment 2

- ▶ Develop your three-sentence ‘elevator pitch’ into a full introduction using the structure explained in the second week.
- ▶ Together with the introduction, you need to write up the first body paragraph in full.
- ▶ Use a third-person perspective (*Smith* describes, concludes, asserts, etc.)
- ▶ Apart from the two fully written out paragraphs, write a few sentences on how you’re planning to develop your paper further, and on what you want to learn from the assignment.



Assignment 3

- ▶ Write a 3-sentence conclusion to your final essay according to the format explained in class.
- ▶ The assignment will be graded on the following aspects:
 - Structure: format of the three-sentence conclusion
 - Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic Idiom
 - Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
- ▶ If you get a fail, you will need to hand in a new version within a couple of days.



Assignment 4

- ▶ Write a 1000-word essay (plus or minus 10%) on a topic of your own choice, related to your academic discipline.
 - ▶ Use at least two to five academic articles, which are framed as a literature review-style text.
 - ▶ Your assignment will be graded (pass/fail) on the following aspects:
 - ▶ Linguistic range and accuracy: grammar, vocabulary, punctuation
 - ▶ Academic style: appropriate level of formality, use of academic idiom
 - ▶ Structure: intro, body, conclusion and a thesis statement covering the content of the entire essay; paragraph structure: topic sentence + elaboration
 - ▶ Use of sources: indication and incorporation of sources in the text; use of referencing style; no traces of plagiarism
 - ▶ Clarity of expression: linking language, clause combining.
 - ▶ Late submissions will not be graded and you will have to wait until the resit date [t.b.a.].
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Suggested Reading

▶ Required

- ▶ Feedback website for Academic English: www.vu.nl/fgw/els-online

▶ Recommended background readings

- ▶ Mike Hannay & J. Lachlan Mackenzie, *Effective Writing in English* (3rd^d edition). 2017. Bussum: Coutinho.
- ▶ Hilary Glasman-Deal, *Science Research Writing for non-native speakers of English*. 2010. London: Imperial College Press.
- ▶ Janene van Loon, Arnoud Thuss, Nicole Schmidt, and Kevin Haines, *Academic Writing in English, a Process-based Approach*. 2011. Bussum: Coutinho.
- ▶ Academic Phrasebank, University of Manchester:
<http://www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/>
- ▶ Online Writing Lab at Purdue:
https://owl.purdue.edu/writinglab/the_writing_lab_at_purdue.html





Introduction to the features of Academic Writing

Accuracy: Grammar, Vocabulary,
Punctuation & Spelling

No spelling mistakes or verb contractions

- ▶ Use your spelling checker (with care!)
 - ▶ It's/its, who's/whose
- ▶ Use your dictionary
 - ▶ <http://dictionary.reference.com/> (useful app available)
 - ▶ Seperate/separate?
 - ▶ Relevance/relavance?
 - ▶ Actual/current?
 - ▶ Shortly/briefly
- ▶ Can't > cannot, doesn't > does not, won't > will not



Required Tool: Source of inspiration

Main resource: ELS-Online

 <https://www2.fgw.vu.nl/els-online/index.php>



Text Structure ▶

Academic Style ▶

Linguistic Range and Accuracy ▶

Clarity of Expression ▶

Assignment Requirements ▶



Faculty of Humanities

Contents

Exercises

Home page

This site contains short texts which explain problematic areas of formal written English. They relate to matters that often cause a problem for learners of English at university level, and for that reason they have been specially coded in the feedback system used for marking written work with the *Markin* programme or *Turnitin's GradeMark* system. The site's focus is not on text content but on language form and text structure, because these are the tools you need in order present content clearly and convincingly.

The texts are organized in five main domains, accessible via the menu bar on the left of the screen, and each domain contains a number of subcategories. There is a short introductory text for each subcategory.

If our feedback on your text has directed you to one or more of the main categories or to specific subcategories, please make sure that you read the relevant text carefully. If you want to understand a problem in its wider context, you can choose to read all the feedback texts for the category concerned. In some cases you will also see a reference to a chapter in a textbook.

In many cases the feedback text will contain a link to exercises related to the topic of the feedback text (on the right of the text), where you can do exercises online, and where you will be given further advice on the basis of your score.

No vocabulary and grammar mistakes

- ▶ Again: use your dictionary!
- ▶ How about “research”? How can you use it? With what phrases can it be combined? Which of the following are correct?
 - ▶ They researched about computers.
 - ▶ Research has shown that...
 - ▶ This research has shown...
 - ▶ Three researches will be discussed in this paper.

British English: <http://www.oxfordlearnersdictionaries.com/> or

- ▶ <http://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/learner-english/>
- ▶ American English: <https://www.merriam-webster.com/>





Sentence structure

No fragments

▶ A good sentence needs:

- a. to be able to stand on its own
- b. a subject (do-er)
- c. a verb (action)
- d. a finite verb (i.e. present or past, singular or plural)
 - ▶ Can be the same as b. but doesn't have to be

▶ Are the following examples fragments or good sentences?

- ▶ Because he knew that it would work.
- ▶ Since they discovered the cure for this disease.
- ▶ These methods, not having been successful in the past.



Signalling language and transitions

- ▶ Guide your reader through the text
- ▶ Show steps in your argument:
 - ▶ “There are three reasons why this is important.”
 - ▶ “First of all...”
 - ▶ “Secondly...”
 - ▶ “Finally...”
- ▶ Show relation between bits of information:
 - ▶ We wanted to learn. We attended the workshop.
 - ▶ We attended the workshop, *because* we wanted to learn.
 - ▶ We wanted to learn, *because* we attended the workshop.
 - ▶ We wanted to learn; *however*, we attended the workshop.





Academic style

Type of text

- ▶ An academic text is impersonal and objective.
- ▶ It deals with questions and answers, not just information.
- ▶ It often contains a discussion and comparison of previous research:
 - ▶ “According to recent studies by Smith, ...”
 - ▶ “Smith proposed Y, but Jones provides evidence against this claim.”



No informal language

- ▶ Rewrite the following sentences so that they are more formal:
 - ▶ Our bank has told us that you haven't made this month's payment.
 - ▶ So, I really think those bosses of international companies don't really care about the law.
 - ▶ The laws are made because we think they're necessary.
 - ▶ We couldn't know ahead of time that there would be an economic disaster.

No emotional language

- ▶ “This idea is ridiculous”
- ▶ “He was, of course, completely wrong”
- ▶ You should also be careful with punctuation.
 - ▶ “The results were different than expected.”
 - ▶ “The results were different than expected!”
- ▶ And with direct questions
 - ▶ “The question is: what is the question?”
 - ▶ The question is whether these two facts can be combined.”



Academic phrases

- ▶ Recent developments in the field of X have led to a renewed interest in ...
- ▶ In the new global economy, X has become a central issue for
- ▶ The issue of X has been a controversial and much disputed subject within the field of
- ▶ There is a consensus among social scientists that
- ▶ A possible explanation for these results may be the lack of adequate

<http://www.phrasebank.manchester.ac.uk/>



Reporting verbs

- ▶ Researchers don't only “say” something, but there are more meaningful verbs to show what a researcher is doing:
 - ▶ Smith **suggests** that “the relative distribution of cases is [...]
 - ▶ Brown **argues** that “the results of the experiments [...]
 - ▶ White **found** that “the mean fitness values [...]
 - ▶ Lewis **shows** that “results of [...]
 - ▶ Loony **describes** the rates [...]
 - ▶ Jones **proposes that** “this idea [...]

Sample student text, original version

Playing video games are a popular form of entertainment, especially among young people. People like to spend a lot of hours behind their television screen playing games sometimes on daily basis. While not acknowledging if they may be harming or improving the health of their brains. Video games can have an affect on your mind, even if you're not aware of it. I think these effects can be either positive or negative. Gamers who often play fast-paced action games, have better perceptual and cognitive skills. Certain types of violent video games can cause more violent thoughts.

Sample student text, improved for *grammar & punctuation*, *sentence structure* and *academic style*.

Playing video games **is** a popular form of entertainment, especially among young people. **These young people** **[deleted: like to]** may spend **many** hours **[deleted: behind their television screen]** playing games, sometimes on **a** daily basis. **However, they do not always acknowledge that** they may be harming or improving the health of their brains. **In fact, there is evidence that video** games can have an **effect** on **the human brain**, even if **gamers are** not aware of it. **[deleted: I think]** These effects can be either positive or negative: **gamers** who often play fast-paced action games **[comma deleted]** have better perceptual and cognitive skills, **while** certain types of violent video games can cause more violent thoughts.



Dos & Don'ts: Summary

Don'ts: summary

- ▶ No emotional language (and punctuation)
- ▶ No informal language
- ▶ No spelling mistakes and verb contractions
- ▶ No fragments
- ▶ No grammatical mistakes



Dos: summary

- ▶ Functions of academic texts: raising and answering questions, discussion/comparison, referring to previous research
- ▶ Objective perspective
- ▶ Signalling language
- ▶ Academic phrases
- ▶ Formality





Writing exercise

Writing exercise (to hand in at end of seminar)

- ▶ 300 words (1 or 2 paragraphs)
- ▶ Spend roughly 15 minutes
- ▶ Write a definition of your field/discipline.
- ▶ Use formal language and an academic perspective
- ▶ Submit on Canvas.





Coming up next

Next week's topic: Introductions

- ▶ Structure of Introductions
- ▶ Grammar issues
- ▶ Instructions for Assignment I (Week 2)

